

# Mapping networks behind ethical sharia debates

Analysis run: September 12, 2026

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PROVIDER

Openrouter

MODEL

Openai/gpt-5.5

LANGUAGE

En

AUDIENCE

GENERAL

INTONATION

NEUTRAL

LENGTH

Long

TEMPERATURE

0.7

## SYSTEM PROMPT

You are an expert AI content generator specializing in creating structured article.

## USER PROMPT

Write a concise, self-contained article entry for the title: "Mapping networks behind ethical sharia debates".

Overall topic for alignment: Intellectual networks shaping humanistic trends in sharia.

Important points to cover: Include Arabic terms, historical contexts, quranic foundations of sharia, minority and majority settings, Islamic theological schools, Islamic juristic schools of Hanafi, Hambali, shafi'i and Malaki, orientalist perspective, AI's humanistic approach to sharia, Human rights declaration..

- Output format: GitHub-Flavored Markdown. The markdown must be clean—do not include any code fences or surrounding markers. Target writing format: Blog Post. Follow these format-specific rules exactly:

- Aim for at least 6000 characters while staying under 12000. Prefer verifiable facts from the provided sources; do not fabricate citations or specific data.

- Place external links only in the "References" section; do not include inline external links in the body text.

- Maximum content length (including headings and references): 12000 characters. If nearing the limit, prioritize the most informative sections and keep references to 2-3.

- Write in the target response language. Avoid fluff; be precise and actionable. Do not include images or tables.

- Do not include code fences or any text outside the markdown content.

No external web sources are attached. Do not fabricate citations or specific facts that cannot be verified. Keep claims general and verifiable. In the 'References' section, include: "No external sources used."

**\*\*Respond in English\*\***

## SUMMARY

The article argues that debates about *sharia* are not only legal disputes but also debates about authority, history, ethics, identity, dignity, and institutional power. Understanding contemporary ethical sharia discourse requires mapping the networks that shape it: Qur'anic interpretation, prophetic practice, juristic schools, theology, state institutions, minority Muslim contexts, human rights discourse, orientalist scholarship, and digital technologies including AI.

A central distinction is between *sharia* as divine guidance and *fiqh* as human jurisprudence. Confusing the two can make historically contingent rulings appear identical with divine law itself. Islamic law developed through interpretation, disagreement, and adaptation, using concepts such as *uṣūl al-fiqh* legal theory, *ijtihād* independent reasoning, *taqlīd* adherence to precedent, *maṣlaḥa* public welfare, *maqāṣid al-sharī'a* higher objectives, justice, mercy, and human dignity.

The Qur'an provides sharia's primary foundation, but not as a modern legal code. Its legal passages sit within a broader moral vision emphasizing worship, justice, mercy, accountability, protection of the vulnerable, truthful conduct, fair dealing, family responsibility, consultation, and the principle that faith cannot be coerced. Because many Qur'anic passages are ethical, narrative, devotional, or theological rather than directly legal, interpretation became necessary.

Historically, sharia developed from the Prophet Muhammad's community in seventh-century Arabia into diverse juristic traditions as Muslim societies expanded into varied regions and political contexts. The Prophet's *sunna* became the second major source after the Qur'an. Later scholars addressed new questions of contracts, courts, evidence, governance, custom, and social change, producing legal pluralism. The four major Sunni schools are presented as interpretive traditions rather than separate religions: Hanafi law is associated with reasoned interpretation, analogy, and juristic preference; Maliki law with the practice of Medina and public welfare; Shafi'i law with disciplined legal methodology and hadith authority; and Hanbali law with textual attachment, while also containing later discussions of public interest, necessity, and reform.

The article stresses that law is shaped by theology. Ash'arī, Māturīdī, Mu'tazilī, and Atharī approaches differ in how they relate divine command, human reason, moral knowledge, and justice. These assumptions affect modern debates about rights, gender, minorities, and reform.

In Muslim-majority settings, sharia debates involve constitutions, courts, ministries, universities, fatwa councils, parties, and civil society. Key questions concern whether sharia should be a source or foundation of legislation, how family and criminal law should operate, who has religious authority, how minorities are protected, and how international human rights commitments are interpreted. In minority-Muslim settings, debates focus more on worship, family life, finance, food, education, citizenship, religious freedom, civil law, custom, necessity, and coexistence. Minority fiqh has

encouraged attention to flexibility, pluralism, and the difference between universal principles and historically political rules.

The article also examines orientalist influence, noting that Western scholarship has both contributed to textual and historical knowledge and been criticized for portraying Islam as static, irrational, legalistic, or anti-modern. This has shaped both external critiques of sharia as incompatible with human rights and internal defensive reactions that may resist needed ethical reform.

Human rights discourse, especially themes such as dignity, equality, freedom of belief, fair trial, education, and protection from torture, has become a major reference point. The article rejects abstract compatibility debates in favor of precise questions: which interpretation of sharia, which right, what kind of conflict, what Islamic tools of reinterpretation exist, and whether vulnerable people are protected. *Maqāṣid al-sharīʿa* is highlighted as a bridge between Islamic sources and contemporary concerns, especially around protection of religion, life, intellect, family, property, dignity, freedom, justice, and welfare.

The article maps seven overlapping networks: textual, juristic, theological, institutional, social, global, and technological. It argues that AI can help summarize, compare, and explain sharia debates, but it has no religious authority and should not issue definitive fatwas. Responsible AI should distinguish sharia, fiqh, state law, custom, and ethics; present juristic diversity; clarify uncertainty; avoid sectarianism; recognize context; and emphasize justice, mercy, dignity, and harm prevention.

A humanistic sharia discourse, the article concludes, does not abandon revelation or simply adopt modern liberal values. It reads the tradition with attention to the people affected by law, asking whether interpretations protect dignity, reduce harm, preserve families, uphold worship, serve justice, and promote the common good. This requires historical humility, methodological clarity, awareness of pluralism, protection of vulnerable groups, careful engagement with human rights, context sensitivity, and responsible scholarship.

## FULL CONTENT

# Mapping networks behind ethical sharia debates

Debates about *sharia* are rarely only about law. They are also debates about authority, history, moral purpose, community identity, and the meaning of human dignity. To understand ethical sharia debates today, it is useful to map the networks behind them: Qur'anic interpretation, prophetic practice, theological schools, juristic traditions, reformist movements, minority Muslim experiences, majority-Muslim state institutions, human rights language, orientalist scholarship, and now artificial intelligence.

This entry offers a concise map of those networks and how they shape humanistic trends in sharia discourse.

## What “sharia” means

The Arabic word *sharīʿa* originally suggests a path or way, often understood as the path to moral and spiritual flourishing. In Islamic usage, it refers to God’s guidance for human life. It is broader than positive law. It includes worship, ethics, social conduct, family relations, commerce, public justice, and personal discipline.

A helpful distinction is between:

- *Sharīʿa*: divine guidance as understood through revelation.
- *Fiqh*: human jurisprudence, or the effort to understand and apply sharia.
- *Uṣūl al-fiqh*: legal theory, the methods used to derive rulings.
- *Fatwā*: a non-binding legal opinion issued by a qualified scholar.
- *Qāḍī*: a judge in a court setting.
- *Maqāṣid al-sharīʿa*: the higher objectives or purposes of sharia.
- *Ijtihād*: disciplined independent reasoning.
- *Taqlīd*: adherence to established scholarly precedent.
- *Maslaḥa*: public interest or welfare.
- *ʿAdl*: justice.
- *Raḥma*: mercy.
- *Karāma*: human dignity.

Many contemporary ethical debates arise because people confuse sharia with *fiqh* or assume that one historical ruling represents the whole of Islamic law. In reality, Islamic law developed through centuries of interpretation, disagreement, and adaptation.

## Qur’anic foundations of ethical sharia

The Qur’an is the primary foundation of sharia. It presents law within a larger moral vision: worship of God, justice among people, protection of the vulnerable, truthful speech, fair trade, family responsibility, restraint in punishment, and mercy.

Several themes are central to humanistic readings of sharia:

- **Justice (*ʿadl* and *qist*)**: Justice is not treated as optional; it is a religious obligation.
- **Mercy (*raḥma*)**: The Qur’an repeatedly frames divine guidance through mercy and compassion.
- **Human dignity (*karāma*)**: Human beings are described as morally significant creatures with responsibility and honor.
- **No compulsion in religion**: The Qur’anic principle that faith cannot be forced has shaped debates on freedom of conscience.

- **Accountability:** Moral responsibility is tied to intention, knowledge, and capacity.
- **Protection of the vulnerable:** Orphans, the poor, travelers, debtors, women in vulnerable situations, and oppressed groups appear repeatedly in Qur’anic ethical concern.
- **Consultation (*shūrā*):** Communal deliberation is treated as a virtue in public affairs.

The Qur’an does not operate like a modern legal code. Some passages are directly legal, but many are ethical, narrative, devotional, or theological. This is why interpretation became necessary and why juristic diversity emerged.

## Historical contexts: from revelation to juristic traditions

Sharia developed in stages. The first context was the life of the Prophet Muhammad in seventh-century Arabia, where revelation addressed worship, tribal conflict, trade practices, marriage, inheritance, warfare, charity, and community formation. The Prophet’s *sunna*—his normative practice—became the second major source after the Qur’an.

After the Prophet’s death, Muslim communities expanded into different regions with varied languages, customs, political systems, and legal cultures. Scholars had to answer new questions: How should contracts be regulated? How should courts work? What counts as reliable evidence? How should Muslims live under changing rulers? How should local custom be treated?

This produced legal pluralism. Different regions developed different scholarly networks, methods, and priorities. Over time, major Sunni juristic schools emerged. Shia legal traditions also developed distinct methods and authorities, though this entry focuses mainly on the four Sunni schools named in the prompt.

The historical lesson is important: sharia debates were never static. They were shaped by teachers, students, judges, merchants, political rulers, textual scholars, theologians, Sufis, reformers, and ordinary believers.

## The four major Sunni juristic schools

The Sunni schools of law, known as *madhāhib*, are not separate religions. They are interpretive traditions. Each school developed principles for reading scripture, weighing evidence, and applying law.

### Hanafi school

The Hanafi school is associated with Abū Ḥanīfa and became influential across Iraq, Central Asia, South Asia, Anatolia, and the Ottoman world. It is often described as giving significant attention to reasoned interpretation, legal analogy (*qiyās*), and juristic preference (*istiḥsān*) within disciplined limits.

In ethical debates, Hanafi reasoning is often invoked where flexibility, commercial complexity, minority life, and administrative law are at issue.

## Maliki school

The Maliki school is associated with Mālik ibn Anas and became prominent in North and West Africa, parts of Arabia, and al-Andalus. It gives notable weight to the practice of the people of Medina as a source of legal understanding. It also has a strong tradition of considering public welfare (*maṣlaḥa*) in legal reasoning.

In contemporary humanistic debates, Maliki concepts are often discussed in relation to social welfare, custom, and communal stability.

## Shafi'i school

The Shafi'i school is associated with al-Shāfi'ī, who played a major role in systematizing *uṣūl al-fiqh*. The school emphasizes disciplined textual reasoning, the authority of hadith, and structured legal methodology.

In modern debates, Shafi'i thought is important because it highlights the need for method. Ethical reform cannot simply be based on preference; it must show how interpretation is justified.

## Hanbali / Hambali school

The Hanbali school is associated with Aḥmad ibn Ḥanbal. It is known for strong attachment to textual sources and caution toward speculative reasoning. However, its later history also includes important discussions of public interest, necessity, and moral reform.

In contemporary debates, Hanbali thought appears in different forms: some emphasize strict textualism, while others highlight ethical governance, accountability, and the objectives of law.

## Islamic theological schools and moral reasoning

Legal debates are connected to theology. Islamic theological schools asked questions such as: What is justice? Can human reason know good and evil? How do divine command and moral truth relate? What is human freedom?

Important theological currents include:

- **Ash'arī theology:** Often associated with emphasis on divine sovereignty and the limits of unaided reason, while still supporting rational theology.
- **Māturīdī theology:** Common in many Hanafi regions, often giving a somewhat larger role to human reason in recognizing moral truths.
- **Mu'tazilī theology:** Historically associated with strong claims about divine justice and the rational knowability of good and evil.
- **Atharī or traditionalist theology:** Emphasizes transmitted texts and caution toward speculative theology.

These schools matter because ethical sharia debates often depend on assumptions about reason, revelation, and moral knowledge. A scholar who believes human reason can identify broad moral goods may approach human rights, gender justice, and minority protections differently from one who is more cautious about ethical reasoning beyond explicit texts.

## Networks in majority-Muslim settings

In majority-Muslim countries, sharia debates often involve state institutions. Constitutions, ministries, courts, universities, fatwa councils, political parties, and civil society organizations all shape the discussion.

Key tensions include:

- Whether sharia should be a source, the main source, or the foundation of legislation.
- How family law should balance tradition, gender equity, and social change.
- Whether criminal law should emphasize deterrence, rehabilitation, procedural safeguards, or symbolic identity.
- How religious authority should be distributed between state-appointed scholars and independent scholars.
- How minority religious communities should be protected.
- How international human rights commitments should be interpreted.

In these settings, the debate is not only “What does Islam say?” but also “Who has the authority to represent Islam in law?” and “How should religious ethics function inside a modern nation-state?”

## Networks in minority-Muslim settings

In minority settings, such as Muslim communities living in secular or religiously plural societies, sharia debates take different forms. Muslims may not control state law, but they still seek to live ethically through worship, family life, finance, food practices, education, and community institutions.

Common questions include:

- How should Muslims follow sharia while respecting the law of the land?
- What does religious freedom mean for Muslims as minorities?
- How should Islamic family ethics interact with civil marriage and divorce law?
- How can Muslim communities prevent isolation while preserving identity?
- What role should local custom (*urf*) play?
- Can minority contexts justify specific legal accommodations through necessity (*darūra*) or public interest (*maṣlaḥa*)?

Minority fiqh has encouraged renewed attention to flexibility, citizenship, coexistence, and the ethics of pluralism. It also challenges Muslim scholars to distinguish between universal principles and rules tied to historical Muslim political power.

## Orientalist perspectives and their influence

“Orientalism” refers broadly to Western scholarly, political, and cultural representations of the East, including Islam. Some orientalist scholarship preserved manuscripts, translated texts, and contributed to historical knowledge. However, orientalist perspectives have also been criticized for presenting Islam as static, irrational, legalistic, or inherently opposed to modernity.

In sharia debates, orientalist influence appears in two opposite ways:

1. **External critique:** Sharia is portrayed as a fixed medieval code incompatible with human rights.
2. **Internal reaction:** Some Muslims respond defensively by treating all criticism as hostile, even when ethical reform is needed.

A balanced approach recognizes both the value and limits of outside scholarship. Non-Muslim scholars can contribute historical and textual insight, but ethical interpretation within Muslim communities also depends on lived religious commitments, Arabic terminology, devotional practice, and internal scholarly authority.

## Human rights and sharia ethics

Modern human rights language, especially the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, has become a major reference point in sharia debates. Its themes include human dignity, equality, freedom of belief, protection from torture, fair trial, education, family rights, and participation in public life.

The relationship between sharia and human rights is complex. Some Muslims argue that human rights express values already present in Islamic ethics, such as dignity, justice, and protection of life. Others worry that modern rights discourse can be individualistic, secular, or disconnected from duties to God and community.

The most productive debates do not ask only whether sharia and human rights are “compatible” in the abstract. They ask more precise questions:

- Which interpretation of sharia is being discussed?
- Which human right is at issue?
- Is the conflict textual, historical, political, or institutional?
- Are there established Islamic tools for reinterpretation?
- Are vulnerable people being protected in practice?
- Does the policy advance justice, mercy, and dignity?

Humanistic sharia discourse often uses *maqāṣid al-sharī'a* to connect Islamic sources with contemporary concerns. The classical objectives are commonly summarized as protection of religion, life, intellect, lineage or family, and property. Contemporary thinkers may also discuss dignity, freedom, justice, and social welfare as overarching objectives.

## Mapping the intellectual networks

Ethical sharia debates are shaped by overlapping networks rather than a single hierarchy. A useful map includes:

### Textual network

This includes the Qur'an, hadith, prophetic biography (*sīra*), legal maxims (*qawā'id fiqhiyya*), and classical commentaries. Humanistic trends often return to foundational texts to emphasize mercy, justice, and accountability.

### Juristic network

This includes the Hanafi, Maliki, Shafi'i, and Hanbali/Hambali schools, along with legal councils and contemporary scholars. Debate often turns on method: analogy, public interest, custom, necessity, consensus (*ijmā'*), and objectives.

### Theological network

This includes Ash'arī, Māturīdī, Mu'tazilī, Atharī, and other approaches to reason and revelation. Theological assumptions influence whether moral values are seen as accessible to reason or known mainly through revelation.

### Institutional network

This includes courts, universities, mosques, state ministries, seminaries, publishers, media platforms, and transnational organizations. Institutions determine which interpretations become law, education, or public opinion.

### Social network

This includes families, women's groups, youth movements, minority communities, converts, migrants, professionals, and activists. Their lived experiences generate questions that older manuals did not always address directly.

## Global network

This includes human rights bodies, international law, interfaith dialogue, academic Islamic studies, orientalist and post-orientalist scholarship, and digital communication. These forces place sharia debates in a global moral vocabulary.

## Technological network

This now includes search engines, social media, online fatwa platforms, translation tools, and AI systems. These tools can democratize access but also spread shallow, decontextualized, or sectarian interpretations.

## AI's humanistic approach to sharia

Artificial intelligence does not possess religious authority. It cannot replace scholars, courts, communities, or moral conscience. However, AI can support a humanistic approach to sharia if designed carefully.

A responsible AI approach should:

- Distinguish between *sharia*, *fiqh*, state law, custom, and personal ethics.
- Present multiple juristic views when diversity exists.
- Identify whether an answer depends on a specific madhhab.
- Avoid issuing definitive fatwas.
- Encourage consultation with qualified scholars for personal or legal matters.
- Highlight ethical principles such as justice, mercy, dignity, and prevention of harm.
- Recognize minority and majority contexts.
- Avoid sectarian framing.
- Clarify uncertainty and historical disagreement.
- Protect users from harmful simplifications, especially in family, criminal, medical, or political matters.

AI can help map debates, summarize arguments, compare schools, explain Arabic terms, and identify ethical questions. But it should not pretend that moral reasoning is merely data retrieval. Humanistic sharia requires wisdom (*hikma*), compassion, accountability, and awareness of lived consequences.

## Toward a humanistic sharia discourse

A humanistic trend in sharia does not mean abandoning revelation or reducing Islam to modern liberal values. It means reading the tradition with attention to the human beings whom law affects. It asks whether interpretations protect dignity, reduce harm, honor worship, preserve families, uphold justice, and serve the common good.

Such a discourse requires several habits:

**1. Historical humility**

Recognize that jurists responded to real contexts. Their work deserves respect, but not every historical answer automatically resolves every modern problem.

**2. Methodological clarity**

Ethical reform should explain its tools: *maqāṣid*, *maṣlaḥa*, *ʿurf*, necessity, textual interpretation, or legal maxims.

**3. Plural awareness**

The existence of Hanafi, Maliki, Shafi'i, and Hanbali traditions shows that disagreement can be disciplined rather than chaotic.

**4. Protection of the vulnerable**

Any sharia debate should ask who bears the cost of a ruling: women, children, minorities, the poor, migrants, prisoners, or dissenters.

**5. Dialogue with human rights**

Human rights language should be neither accepted uncritically nor rejected reflexively. It should be examined through Islamic concepts of justice, dignity, duty, and welfare.

**6. Context sensitivity**

Muslim-majority and Muslim-minority settings require different legal and ethical strategies. Citizenship, public order, and religious freedom must be considered.

**7. Responsible scholarship**

Scholars, activists, AI systems, and public commentators should avoid turning complex jurisprudence into slogans.

## Conclusion

Mapping the networks behind ethical sharia debates reveals a tradition that is textual, historical, plural, and morally ambitious. Sharia is not simply a list of rules; it is a field of interpretation rooted in the Qur'an, shaped by prophetic practice, developed through juristic schools, debated by theologians, administered by institutions, challenged by modern human rights discourse, and now mediated by digital technologies.

The central question is not whether sharia has an ethical dimension. It clearly does. The deeper question is how Muslims and their interlocutors identify, interpret, and institutionalize that ethical dimension in ways that honor God, protect human dignity, and serve justice in changing societies.

**SEGMENTED DATA (2)**

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family, and property. Contemporary thinkers may also discuss dignity, freedom, justice, and social welfare as overarching objectives.

## Mapping the intellectual networks

Ethical sharia debates are shaped by overlapping networks rather than a single hierarchy. A useful map includes:

### Textual network

This includes the Qur'an, hadith, prophetic biography (*sīra*), legal maxims (*qawā'id fiqhīyya*), and classical commentaries. Humanistic trends often return to foundational texts to emphasize mercy, justice, and accountability.

### Juristic network

This includes the Hanafi, Maliki, Shafi'i, and Hanbali/Hambali schools, along with legal councils and contemporary scholars. Debate often turns on method: analogy, public interest, custom, necessity, consensus (*ijmā'*), and objectives.

### Theological network

This includes Ash'arī, Māturīdī, Mu'tazilī, Atharī, and other approaches to reason and revelation. Theological assumptions influence whether moral values are seen as accessible to reason or known mainly through revelation.

### Institutional network

This includes courts, universities, mosques, state ministries, seminaries, publishers, media platforms, and transnational organizations. Institutions determine which interpretations become law, education, or public opinion.

### Social network

This includes families, women's groups, youth movements, minority communities, converts, migrants, professionals, and activists. Their lived experiences generate questions that older manuals did not always address directly.

### Global network

This includes human rights bodies, international law, interfaith dialogue, academic Islamic studies, orientalist and post-orientalist scholarship, and digital communication. These forces place sharia debates in a global moral vocabulary.

## Technological network

This now includes search engines, social media, online fatwa platforms, translation tools, and AI systems. These tools can democratize access but also spread shallow, decontextualized, or sectarian interpretations.

## AI's humanistic approach to sharia

Artificial intelligence does not possess religious authority. It cannot replace scholars, courts, communities, or moral conscience. However, AI can support a humanistic approach to sharia if designed carefully.

A responsible AI approach should:

- Distinguish between *sharia*, *fiqh*, state law, custom, and personal ethics.
- Present multiple juristic views when diversity exists.
- Identify whether an answer depends on a specific madhhab.
- Avoid issuing definitive fatwas.
- Encourage consultation with qualified scholars for personal or legal matters.
- Highlight ethical principles such as justice, mercy, dignity, and prevention of harm.
- Recognize minority and majority contexts.
- Avoid sectarian framing.
- Clarify uncertainty and historical disagreement.
- Protect users from harmful simplifications, especially in family, criminal, medical, or political matters.

AI can help map debates, summarize arguments, compare schools, explain Arabic terms, and identify ethical questions. But it should not pretend that moral reasoning is merely data retrieval. Humanistic sharia requires wisdom (*hikma*), compassion, accountability, and awareness of lived consequences.

## Toward a humanistic sharia discourse

A humanistic trend in sharia does not mean abandoning revelation or reducing Islam to modern liberal values. It means reading the tradition with attention to the human beings whom law affects. It asks whether interpretations protect dignity, reduce harm, honor worship, preserve families, uphold justice, and serve the common good.

Such a discourse requires several habits:

### 1. Historical humility

Recognize that jurists responded to real contexts. Their work deserves respect, but not every historical answer automatically resolves every modern problem.

### 2. Methodological clarity

Ethical reform should explain its tools: *maqāṣid*, *maṣlaḥa*, *urf*, necessity, textual interpretation, or legal maxims.

### 3. Plural awareness

The existence of Hanafi, Maliki, Shafi'i, and Hanbali traditions shows that disagreement can be disciplined rather than chaotic.

#### **4. Protection of the vulnerable**

Any sharia debate should ask who bears the cost of a ruling: women, children, minorities, the poor, migrants, prisoners, or dissenters.

#### **5. Dialogue with human rights**

Human rights language should be neither accepted uncritically nor rejected reflexively. It should be examined through Islamic concepts of justice, dignity, duty, and welfare.

#### **6. Context sensitivity**

Muslim-majority and Muslim-minority settings require different legal and ethical strategies. Citizenship, public order, and religious freedom must be considered.

#### **7. Responsible scholarship**

Scholars, activists, AI systems, and public commentators should avoid turning complex jurisprudence into slogans.

## **Conclusion**

Mapping the networks behind ethical sharia debates reveals a tradition that is textual, historical, plural, and morally ambitious. Sharia is not simply a list of rules; it is a field of interpretation rooted in the Qur'an, shaped by prophetic practice, developed through juristic schools, debated by theologians, administered by institutions, challenged by modern human rights discourse, and now mediated by digital technologies.

The central question is not whether sharia has an ethical dimension. It clearly does. The deeper question is how Muslims and their interlocutors identify, interpret, and institutionalize that ethical dimension in ways that honor God, protect human dignity, and serve justice in changing societies.